

RUEBENGGRAYAPPEDIT

Travel Radio Australia, and we are speaking from our studios on the Gold Coast. In Bali at the moment is Ruben Gray, the CEO of King of the Hill Nepal, the world's highest luxury ski tours. And they also have the King of the Hill app that you can get, which is very interesting too.

Ruben, welcome to the programme. Hi, how's it going? Thanks so much for having me. I've been looking at what you've been doing, and you have an incredible background with the Alps in Nepal and all over the place, really.

Tell me about the time you walked 690 miles in ski boots between London and the Alps. Now, that sounds a bit epic to me. Yeah, it was described by many as one of the stupidest things you could possibly do.

It was me and my co-founder who started King of the Hill about three years ago. And two years ago, we decided that a good way to get into the skiing ecosystem and for people to find out about us, but also to raise a good amount of money for charity would be to do something that no one's ever done before. And at the time, we looked into loads of different expeditions and loads of crazy different things we could possibly do.

But someone who just ran the length of Africa is known as a rust cook or the hardest geezer. We were like, I wonder if anyone's ever done a long distance in ski boots before? And we discovered that only sort of the longest distance had been done was a marathon. So we thought, you know what, if we're going to do it, we may as well do it properly.

We were launching the King of the Hill company in Valtarennes in the French Alps, and we were in London at the time. And we decided a good idea would be to walk from London to the Alps in ski boots with skis on our back. Little did we know really how horrendous it would be.

It was probably one of the hardest things ever. It was not straightforward. I think the main reasons we did it really was, number one, the person that introduced me to adventures and skiing and surfing and all these incredible things in life was a man named Jerry Childers.

He was my godfather. When I was about 13 years old, he put me on a ski list and he said, hey, Ruben, we're going to do a race. And as a 13-year-old, you're pretty excited when someone says you're going to race them.

So I was like, OK, well, what's the race called? And he called it the King of the Hill race, funny enough. And as we were going up this ski lift, he was telling me all of these different rules, you know, don't start early, make sure your boots are done correctly, goggles on, don't hit any kids on the way down, all of that sort of stuff. Just as he was lifting up the bar, now, I won't swear, but you can imagine what he said.

But just as he was lifting up the bar, he said, Ruben, there's one last rule. I went, oh, what's that, Jerry? What's that? And he said, there are no bleep word rules and pushed me over and skied down as quickly as he could. Now, sadly, Jerry passed away in 2018 of pancreatic cancer, and he was the one that introduced me to all of these amazing things.

So we raised money for Macmillan Cancer Support, which is a big charity in the UK, and we also raised money for a charity called Snow Camp, which do amazing things for getting inner-city kids out into the mountains, getting them qualifications and getting them out to become instructors or getting out of their everyday lives. So we were really excited by that. It took us 50 days exactly.

It was half a marathon a day in ski boots, all the way from London all the way down. We had a bit of a detour on the way as well. We stopped off in Luxembourg, which is completely the wrong way to go.

And it was, yeah, one of the most painful but eye-opening sort of experiences I've ever had, and I think maybe cemented us slightly in the European ski world. But, yeah, we're still working hard on that aspect of things. Sounds like an incredible story, and it really, really was an amazing achievement.

And thank you so much for all the money you raised for those really great causes, especially Snow Camp. Snow Camp is such an amazing organisation and helps so many disadvantaged kids to get into the snow. Now, you have a big expedition coming up in 2027, and I'll be reading about it.

It just sounds incredible. You're taking about 30 people up. It's 17th to the 27th of February, 2027.

You're actually taking them up there for a massive dinner, a five-star dinner, right on the mountain. Tell us about this. It's an incredible 10-day experience.

We're going to a place that has recently been open to the public in the Annapurna region of Nepal. So it's actually on the western side of Nepal, not the eastern side, which Everest is on the eastern. Then you have the western side, where you're looking at the Dhaulagiri Range, Tibet, all the way up to sort of Kashmir and Pakistan, all over there.

Yeah, King of the Hill Nepal is probably one of the most exciting things happening in extreme and luxury ski tours at the moment. It's the first ever luxury ski tour in the Nepali Himalayas. It is starting in Kathmandu.

It's a full 10-day cultural experience while also being a skiing experience. You have three days going from Kathmandu all the way to Upper Mustang. On the way, you're going through multiple different sort of environments.

You're going from city to rainforest to upper altitude desert. And it's one of the craziest cultural

things I've ever done anyway. I was actually out there in March this year and February this year with our amazing guide who is known as Krish Appamaga.

Now, Krish is probably one of the most interesting people I've ever met in my life. I'll get onto him in a minute. But we stopped off at Krish's village.

We then went up to 3,800 metres in a place called Mukdinath, which is a very world-famous Hindu site where they've got a temple. We actually ski from that temple for two days of the trip. And then the last four days of the trip, we're at altitude.

We're at 4,600 metres, which is where the festival base camp is or the tour base camp is. We've got a main dome. Everyone has their own private luxury tent.

Everyone has their own porter. We have multiple guides, snowmobiles, and you can ski all the way up to 6,000 metres depending on how you decline the tide throughout the time. It's untouched.

No one has ever skied it before. And the expertise that we're bringing on this trip is second to none. People that have climbed Everest multiple times, people that have skied down 8,000-metre peaks.

There is not another tour in the world that offers that sort of expertise. And that's why we're so excited to finally be bringing skiing to Nepal because it's just not a done thing in Nepal. It sounds absolutely incredible.

And the warrior monk, Krish Tapamaga, I mean, I've been looking at his background. He's got an incredible military background. If you wanted anyone to be looking after you, you wanted a guy like this, it sounds like he could take on the whole, you know, half the planet.

He's a pretty tough guy. He's funny enough, you know. He's, as I said, the most interesting man I've ever met.

We came across Krish two years ago in London. And we were just at this event where they were launching some sort of brand of vodka, I think it was at the time. Krish doesn't drink, but he was there nevertheless.

And we sort of went up and started talking to him. And he's such a humble man. You would never know any of the accolades and the things that he's done.

But to give you a list of a few, he spent 25 years in the 22 SAS, or the 22 SAS, which is the top of the top in the British military. He started off as 19 years as a Buddhist monk, joined the Gurkhas when he was 18, and ended up becoming one of the first Gurkhas to be in the SAS, was there for 25 years, became the head of the mountain troop. And then after that, started to guide on some of the most extreme mountains in the world.

So he took the first group of Gurkhas up Everest. He actually also took the pride of Britain winner, Harry Bagdamaga, up Everest, who's the first ever double amputee to climb Everest. And that was in 2023.

And recently, he's just come back from an expedition where they were doing the world's highest face jump. He recently got back from that two weeks ago. And he was the team leader there.

And they were jumping off Everest with a parachute on. So in terms of sort of what he's done before... Just throw that in, you know. Yeah.

And in terms of sort of his expertise on that standard, he's done absolutely everything under the sun. I think 13 Everest, K2. He was the first guy to ever ski off the seventh highest mountain in the world, which stands at 8,147 metres.

And I can never pronounce it correctly, but it's Durgaliri, I think is the British pronunciation, but I'm sure someone will correct me. But yeah, a really, really cool guy. And the really lovely thing about where it is that this tour is happening is it is above where he grew up.

He's been looking at this face and these mountains for years. He's actually... He's been wanting to take people here for 20 years. And now all of the sort of elements of the lines, and we're finally able to launch it as King of the Hill of the Pool.

It's not just going to be a one-off ski tour as well. The first one happens next February. But after that, we're going to be looking at doing two to three a year where we can show the amazing skiing that is in the pool to the rest of the world.

And that's one thing I think everyone knows in the pool for climbing, for trekking. Barely anyone skis there. There's no infrastructure.

So to be able to bring that to those people and to that country is one of the most exciting things I think I've ever had the pleasure of being able to do, but also anyone could ever do. It was the most incredible experience of my life the first time I went there. I'm really excited to let people in.

And the fact that there's only 30 people, I mean, every one of those people will be incredible and the interactions, I can imagine, are just going to be insane between those people. They'll all be really amazing personalities. I'd hope so, you know.

I mean, we have an incredible group that are already signed up to come along. I think, you know, if you're an adventurous, outgoing person, you skied, let's say the Alps, you skied Australia, you skied New Zealand, but you're looking for something a little bit off the beaten track, but still not, you know, we're not talking, we're not going to take you down the most dangerous terrain on Earth. That's not what this is about.

This is about showing you culture and showing you skiing in a completely new light. But yeah, I

think that the people that are coming, to be honest with you, is a really awesome mix. We've got all the way from, you know, companies, sold their companies coming along because they've skied everything, they could be skied and they want to try something new.

And I think that's one of the really lovely things is that there's a real mixture, an ability level, as well as sort of people. King of the Hill Nepal app, how can people get onto that? So I suppose you're on all the platforms? Yeah, so King of the Hill, the app, and King of the Hill Nepal are two separate things. So King of the Hill, the app, is essentially, if you could imagine, Strava for skiing, however, at the end of each season, we offer up a big prize.

So for whoever's got the highest rating on the app. So you press start while you go skiing on the King of the Hill app. You ski along.

You see where you're rating the global leaderboards. And if you win by the end of the season, we take you on an amazing trip. So for example, last year, we took someone heli skiing in Italy, which is quite an amazing thing to do.

Awesome, this guy had never been heli skiing before. He actually was working as a bartender in a ski resort. And he was like, I'd never yet yet to do this in my life.

This would be amazing. And it was a really beautiful thing to do. So the app itself is completely separate from Nepal, but we love to run it because it allows us to take people on really cool experiences.

But then the Nepal trip itself is really the mother of all trips. I think that's going to be very, very exciting for anyone that gets the chance to come along. And especially if they're one of the first people to come on a King of the Hill trip, I think over the next few years, they'll see we're going to be opening up in a few new places that are untouched and unskeen and are going to have first dibs on those as well.

Reuben Grey, it's been a pleasure having you on the program from the King of the Hill app. Just search King of the Hill on Google or LinkedIn or any of the platforms. And Reuben Grey, that's R-E-U-B-E-N, Grey, G-I-R-A-Y.

And it's been a pleasure finding out about all your fantastic trips and the app on Travel Radio Australia. And thanks for being with us. Thanks so much for having me.

I hope you have a lovely rest of your day.